



Exploratory User Research

Define the participant sample

Defining the participant sample means deciding who you need to talk to in order to understand the problem space and user context relevant to your project.

[Learn more in the UX/UI Guidance section](#)

Why does it matter in this phase?

In exploratory user research, the goal is not representativeness, but **diversity of perspectives**. A well-defined participant sample helps ensure that the collected data is **relevant, credible, and aligned with the research goals**, while preventing the collection of redundant or misleading insights.

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Step by step guidance



Define inclusion criteria

Specify the characteristics participants must have to be relevant for the study (e.g. role, experience level, domain familiarity).

Students currently writing theses

Students using existing university apps



Define exclusion criteria

Clarify which profiles should not be included, to avoid bias or irrelevant perspectives.

University security staff

Professors



Decide approximate number of participants

Determine a realistic number of participants based on time constraints, research goals, and the exploratory nature of the study.

Around 20 Interviews



Document rationale

Briefly explain why this sample is appropriate for the project context and research questions.

Documentation to produce



Don't forget to upload them in the documentation section!



Participant profile description

A concise description of the types of participants involved in the study.



Recruitment criteria

A list of inclusion and exclusion criteria used to select participants.



Sample size justification

A short explanation supporting the chosen number of participants.

Recommended tools



User Testing



Maze



Ethnio

Assignee



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